Religious Studies - Structural Correspondence with the 5-Stage Model

2026-03-21

Contents

Religious Studies . . . 1
Survey Overview . . . 1
Structural Correspondence Diagram . . . 1
Overview of the 5-Stage Model . . . 1
Overview of Structural Correspondences . . . 2
Key Entry 1: Rambo's 7-Stage Conversion Model (Lewis R. Rambo) . . . 2
Key Entry 2: Turner's Liminality and Structure/Anti-Structure (Victor Turner) . . . 5
Key Entry 3: Teresa of Avila's *Interior Castle* — Seven Mansions . . . 5
Cross-Cutting Patterns . . . 6
Unresolved Questions . . . 6
Conclusion . . . 7

Religious Studies

Structural correspondence survey with the 5-stage model (Ba / Wave / En / Uzu / Taba)

Survey Overview

- **Survey target**: 10 major theories in religious studies
- **Research question**: Do the various theories of religious studies correspond structurally to the 5-stage model?
- **Results**: Strong correspondence in 1 case, partial correspondence in 1 case, conditional correspondence in 2 cases

---

Structural Correspondence Diagram

Overview of the 5-Stage Model

Stage	Definition
Ba (Field)	An undifferentiated state. The initial condition in which no direction or structure has yet been established
Wave	The exploratory stage in which multiple directions diverge and compete
En (Edge)	A state of tension in which opposing elements coexist without converging on either side. The place where they meet at the boundary, influence each other, and relationships emerge

Stage	Definition
Uzu (Vortex)	The stage in which a new coherence (order) arises spontaneously from within the tension
Taba (Bundle)	The stage in which the form is fixed and stabilizes as a reusable structure

---

Overview of Structural Correspondences

Confidence	Theory group	Positioning
Strong correspondence	Rambo's 7-stage conversion model, Eliade's sacred and profane, Oxherding Pictures, Bodhisattva ten stages / five paths, Fana/Baqa, Maqamat	The correspondence with the overall 5-stage structure is clear
Partial correspondence	Teresa of Avila's seven mansions, Turner's liminality, Alchemical Magnum Opus	The overall structural correspondence exists, but compression or interpretive leaps remain in the first or second half
Conditional correspondence	James's religious experience	The theory does not present a stage model, so structural correspondence depends on a constructive reading by the analyst

---

Key Entry 1: Rambo's 7-Stage Conversion Model (Lewis R. Rambo)

- Rambo described religious conversion as an integrated 7-stage model: context, crisis, quest, encounter, interaction, commitment, and consequences. Presented in his 1993 book *Understanding Religious Conversion*, this model integrates conversion from multiple perspectives — psychological, sociological, and theological — and explicitly states that the stages are interactive rather than sequentially fixed.
- **As a matter of fact**: Rambo positioned the conversion process as a phenomenon occurring within a "dynamic force field," a conceptual framework influenced by Kurt Lewin's field theory, in which individual inner motivation, social networks, and cultural context constitute the "force field." The 7 stages have the overall structure of "environment → disruption → quest → contact → relational reorganization → convergence → consolidation."
- **As an interpretation of structure**: Here we attend to the fact that the overall process of transformation can be read as "environment (preconditions) → disruption (turbulence in existing order) → relational reorganization at the boundary → convergence toward a new order → sustained consolidation." The level of similarity is process. Particular attention is given to the point that the concept of "dynamic force field" is explicitly described as the precondition for transformation, and that "encounter" and "interaction" are articulated as the process of establishing and reweaving relationships.
- **As an interpretive reading**: The overall 7-stage structure shows high correspondence with the 5 stages. "Context" corresponds to Ba as the "dynamic force field" in which conversion occurs. "Crisis + Quest" is the phase in which existing meaning order is shaken and differences emerge, corresponding to Wave. "Encounter + Interaction" is boundary contact with embodied others and relational reorganization, corresponding to En. "Commitment" is convergence through pledge, corresponding to Uzu, and "Consequences" is the sustained consolidation of transformation, corresponding to Taba. The fact that Rambo himself positions conversion as "a process occurring within a dynamic force field" shows that the correspondence with Ba is structural rather than a superficial naming coincidence.

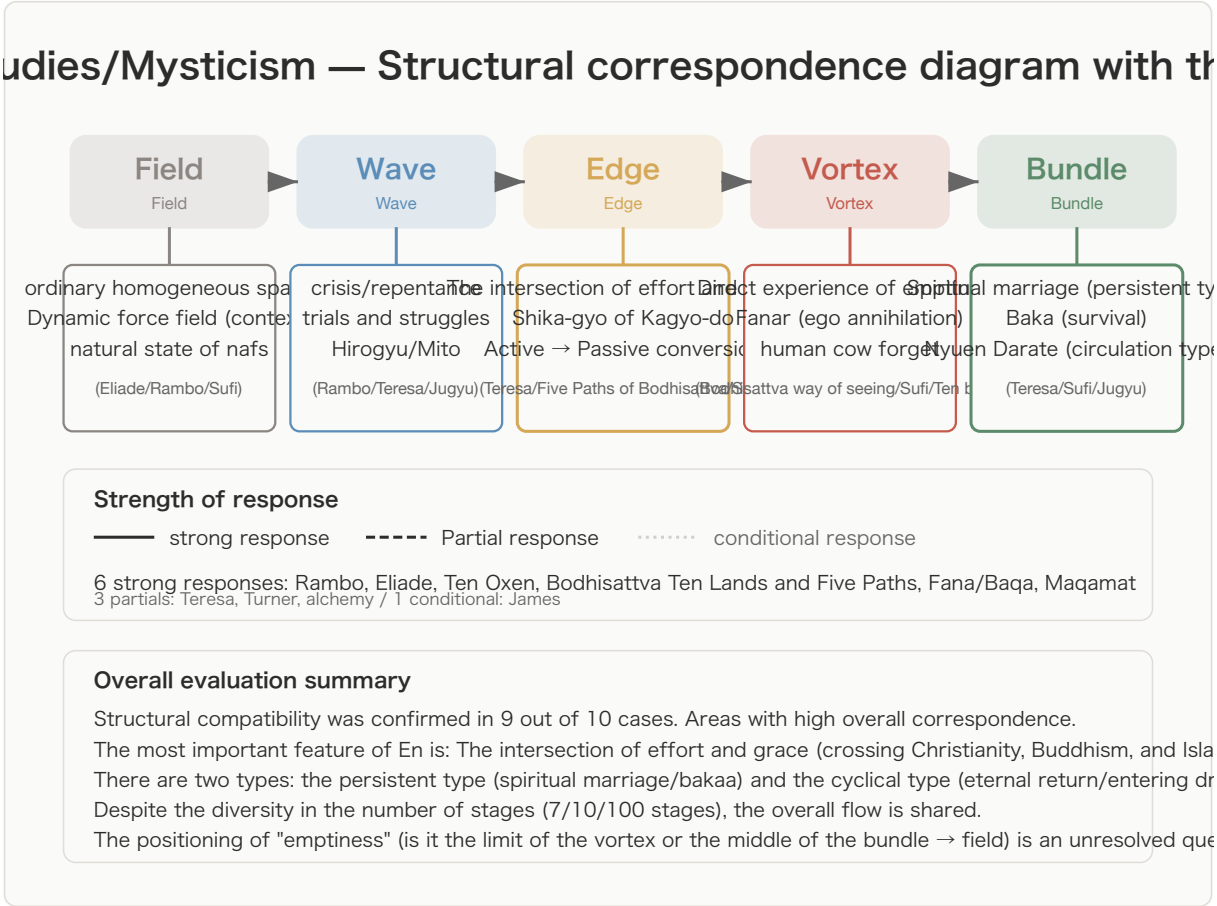

Figure 1: Structural correspondence diagram

Figure 2: Domain — Theory x 5-Stage Correspondence Matrix

- It should be noted that in compressing 7 stages to 5, the position of "Quest" is prone to wobble. Whether it is included in Wave or treated as the first half of En changes the reading. "Quest" is the stage of active searching between Wave and En, and can also be read as making explicit what the 5 stages implicitly contain: "the interval between when difference has arisen and when relationship has been established."

Key Entry 2: Turner's Liminality and Structure/Anti-Structure (Victor Turner)

- Turner extended the three phases of rites of passage (separation-threshold-incorporation) proposed by anthropologist van Gennep, and uniquely conceptualized the threshold period (liminality) as "betwixt and between." Presented in his 1969 book *The Ritual Process*, this theory, together with the concept of communitas — the non-structural communality located outside social structure — has become a foundational theory in the anthropology of religion.
- **As a matter of fact**: Turner presented a dialectical cycle of structure → anti-structure (communitas) → re-structuration. Participants in liminality are placed in a state where existing social classifications are suspended and normal status and roles are stripped away. There are three types of communitas: spontaneous communitas — a direct encounter between people unmediated by structure; normative communitas; and ideological communitas, which becomes progressively institutionalized.
- **As an interpretation of structure**: Here we read the structure of the "threshold" (kiwa) at which old order is suspended and new relational qualities emerge. The level of similarity is structure, with particular attention to the relational arrangement in which "existing structural distinctions are temporarily lifted, and new relationships are woven within that lifting." The fact that Turner finds sacred and creative value in liminality/communitas itself can be read as the claim that the boundary state is not merely a passage but is itself the source of society's fundamental energy.
- **As an interpretive reading**: The three phases of separation → threshold → incorporation correspond structurally to the 5-stage "Wave (turbulence, separation) → En (threshold, relationship) → Uzu (arising, incorporation)." The "betwixt and between" state of liminality is a strong realization of En. Furthermore, the dialectical cycle of structure → anti-structure → re-structuration can be connected to the 5-stage Taba → Ba cycle. However, in mapping 3 stages onto 5, the correspondence of "Ba" and "Taba" depends on interpretation. Whether the social structure prior to the ritual is taken as "Ba" or "Taba" can be resolved by reading it as a cyclic model, but this point requires attention.

Key Entry 3: Teresa of Avila's *Interior Castle* — Seven Mansions

- Teresa (1515-1582) used the metaphor of a castle to describe the interior of the human being, and described spiritual progression through seven mansions (moradas). Written in 1577, *El Castillo Interior* (Interior Castle) is a classic work of Christian mysticism, paired with John of the Cross's *Dark Night* as the twin pillars of Spanish mysticism.
- **As a matter of fact**: The first mansion begins with recognition of the soul's dignity, and it is explicitly stated that "the gate to enter the castle is prayer." The second through third mansions are stages of patience and struggle, continuing the confrontation with forces that obstruct the continuation of practice. A decisive turning point occurs in the fourth mansion. Teresa here made a clear distinction between "consolations (contentos)" and "spiritual delights (gustos)." The former are obtained through human effort; the latter are given by God. This stage, where the prayer of recollection (oración de recogimiento) begins, is the turning point from "active prayer" to "passive prayer." In the fifth through sixth mansions, prayer of union with God, ecstasy (éxtasis), and rapture occur, and trials are most intense in the sixth mansion. In the seventh mansion, spiritual marriage (matrimonio espiritual) is reached, and Teresa speaks of the necessity that Martha and Mary be together — the integration of contemplation and action. Ecstasy disappears, and ordinary acts are conducted in stable peace.
- **As an interpretation of structure**: Here we read the "qualitative shift from active to passive" in the fourth mansion as a structural turning point in the transformation process. The level of similarity is process, with particular attention to the order of the shift in which "something of a

different quality is given beyond the limit of the subject's effort." We also read the integration of contemplation and action in the seventh mansion as the structure in which transformation becomes consolidated into daily life.

- **As an interpretive reading**: The overall structure of the seven mansions corresponds to the 5 stages. The first mansion (entry into Ba) → the second through third mansions (trials and struggle = Wave) → the fourth mansion (qualitative shift in prayer = En) → the fifth through sixth mansions (mystical union = Uzu) → the seventh mansion (spiritual marriage = Taba). The strongest correspondence is between the seventh mansion and Taba. The integration of Martha and Mary — contemplative life and active life becoming one — clearly realizes Taba as "a gathering where vortices influence each other and remain as structure," in the spiritual domain. However, in compressing 7 stages to 5, there is a danger that the qualitative difference between contentos/gustos that Teresa painstakingly distinguished is concealed under the abstract language of the 5 stages. This loss of information is a methodological point of caution.

Cross-Cutting Patterns

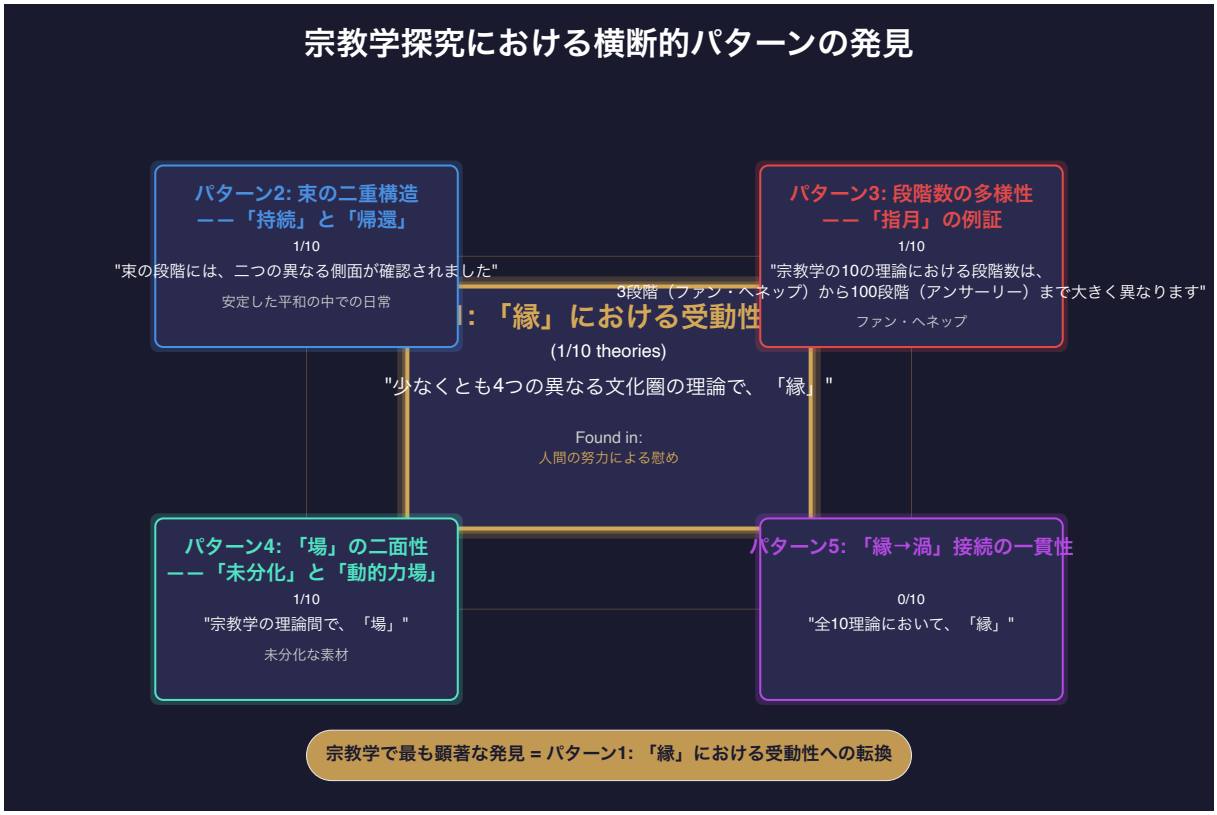

Figure 3: Domain — Cross-Cutting Patterns Diagram

- The pattern that recurs most frequently across religious studies and mysticism is the intertwining of effort and grace in En
- Second, two types of Taba are confirmed
- Third, the diversity of stage counts itself is an important finding

---

Unresolved Questions

- **The relationship between effort and grace in En**: The distinction between "what is reached by effort / what is given as grace" seen commonly in Teresa, Sufism, and Buddhism — how should this be reflected in En of the 5 stages? Whether En is an active or passive process — probably both — but how to integrate them remains unresolved.

- **The positioning of "emptiness"**: The "forgetting of both person and ox" in the Oxherding Pictures, Fana, and the transition from the path of preparation to the path of seeing all contain a stage of "complete dissolution" in the process leading to Uzu. This "emptiness" is not explicitly present in the 5 stages. Whether it is located between Taba and Ba in the cycle, or is the extreme of Uzu, or is a different dimension outside the 5 stages, is a question with conflicting interpretations remaining.
- **The legitimacy of compressing stage counts**: Compression from 7→5, 10→5, 100→5 is structurally permissible, but the qualitative differences unique to each stage — Teresa's contentos/gustos, the four preparations of the path of preparation, individual maqams in Maqamat — are lost. How much this loss of information is permissible is a methodological challenge.
- **Self-referentiality with Eliade's methodological critique**: The method of the 5-stage model pointing to "structural similarities" with religious practice hierarchies is structurally isomorphic with the method of Eliade's comparative religion. The critique of "arbitrary comparison" that Eliade has faced is applicable to the 5-stage model as well, and this self-referential tension needs to be recognized.

Conclusion

- This survey confirmed that religious studies and mysticism is a domain with overall high structural similarity to the 5-stage model
- The structural correspondence is particularly strong in: Rambo's 7-stage conversion model (the "dynamic force field" concept corresponds structurally to Ba), Bodhisattva ten stages/five paths (the path of preparation describes the internal structure of En in detail), the Oxherding Pictures (the "entering the world with helping hands" pictorially expresses the Taba → Ba cycle), and Eliade's eternal return (a civilization-scale description of the Taba → Ba cycle)
- The findings of this survey are considered to be in the compelling confidence band regarding the intertwining pattern of effort and grace in En, and the dual nature of Taba as persistent/cyclic